

Symbol	Context and connected characters	Potential interpretation and link to themes	Connected Dialogue and stage directions
Dolly's dress	The Miss Mooroopna-Shepparton ball, Nan made it for Dolly, but was of fabric from Daish's which were Nancy's family's curtains	- Represents her dreams and desire to be included in white society → but demonstrates Indigenous struggles and exclusion through it being made of tip fabric that Nancy recognises and makes fun of. - Tension between socio-economic status and dreams.	"My dress? Courtesy of the town bloody tip?" – Dolly, page 166
Gladys' flowers	Gladys holding very wilted flowers after coming back from trying to see the Queen	- Crushed hope and disappointment - Energy drained, reflecting in the flowers - Care of collecting flowers met with exclusion (hessian) mirrors Gladys' optimism and faith in wanting change being eroded.	"The hessian they lined the road with." – Gladys, page 127
The cork trees	Nan tells Dolly to go to school but warns her to not go near the cork trees because of her drunk cousins	- Rough trees → Dolly's rough future, dreaming to escape from the inevitability of her fate - Cork trees aren't native to Australia, and it being the cousins hangout can symbolise displacement, hence Nan preventing Dolly from going near it, so she's protected from negativity drawing her there. Tries to maintain Dolly's will and persistence for life. - Juxtapose the innocence of school with the sorrow of losing it - Symbolises bad future and bad consequences	"But keep away from them cork trees." – Nan, page 126
Que sera, sera	A song that repetitively appears at the front, throughout and at the end of the book, meaning whatever will be will be.	- Acceptance of fate, almost encouraging them to continue resigning to their circumstances. Yet highlights their resilience to persevere through hardships. Reminds them to endure and the fact it'll pass. - Familial bonds → their song - Tension between hope and resignation - Powerlessness in the face of fate	"That's it then, Que sera sera. Please don't tell mum about the cork trees." – Dolly, page 188. ➔ Close encounter with negativity, doesn't want to think about it, is recentered with supportive family ➔ The song before talking about her rape implies it was inevitable, as she "knew that'd happen". – page 168

Dolly's magazines	Nan using Dolly's magazines to repair the humpy because they're dry	- Magazines symbolise Dolly's dreams and aspirations, her desire for a life beyond her current one. - Them being used for the humpy represents how her dreams and childhood must be sacrificed to deal with survival → no room for luxury or relaxation. However Nan tries to give it back to her when she tells Dolly to go "play while shes still a kid". - Reminder of real struggles and living conditions that prevent her from ever achieving her dreams → she resigns. - Inability to escape, she'd do anything to survive. - Can be a good thing, making the best out of a bad situation, resilience in repurposing magazines, prioritising survival, reminder it will get better.	Gladys: "They're Dolly's." → tries to maintain childhood Nan: "They're dry." → focuses on necessities Page 1
Encyclopedias	Errol meets the women by taking a wrong turn and begins selling the encyclopedias to them	- Aspirations for better circumstances - Nan weary of how government erased Aboriginal culture and knowledge - Errol has little need for them, yet can't talk properly, highlights his white privilege, juxtaposes Gladys' efforts to get the encyclopedias → differences in appreciation of luxuries such as education.	"Ask him what it says in that there encyclops about the Aborigines eh?" – Nan, page "Encyclops boy and he know nothing!" – Nan, page
Biyala tree	Nan mistakes Dolly's school project of the family tree for her talking about the Biyala tree	- Constant connection and reminder of country and ancestors - Resilience of culture, as it's an old tree - Symbolises life and renewal → reminder things will be better - Spiritual bond to ancestry, always on Nan's mind.	"The Biyala? Spirit tree with the low hanging branches?" – Nan, page
The family tree	Dolly's school project is to make a family tree	- Connection to ancestry → surprising they let Dolly do it due to her being Indigenous - Symbol of identity and pride as a minority in a dominant white society	"I need to list all our family members...our parents and their parents and so on..." – Dolly, page

The pram	The pram is used to hold the kero tin and other things for usefulness	- Theft of innocence, and childhood being taken too soon to be used for survival purposes. - Not a safe environment for babies?	"Lights come up on Dolly pushing the pram." – stage direction, page 132 "Triumphantly she (Gladys) pulls an obviously bashed can from the pram." – stage directions, page 143
Swan eggs	Nan says she will never die until she returns to the Murray River and have a serve of swan eggs	- Connection to country and tradition - Maintaining cultural heritage and identity, refusing to die on whitewashed land, and refusal to die in a way that doesn't reflect her culture	"
The hessian	Indigenous housing being blocked off by hessian from the government when the Queen comes to visit so she can't see them	- Being covered by hessian demonstrates neglect and disrespect for Indigenous Australians → embarrassment of them, yet they're the ones who put them at a disadvantage. - Coarse fabric → harsh realities of being hidden, silenced and discriminated against - Render them invisible, they're ashamed of them - Façade of respectability for the Queen	"Stop the likes of her seeing our humpies." – Gladys, page 127 "But hessian! Like a bandaid over a sore-" – Gladys page 127 "What good is it if I get het up?" – Nan, page 128
The humpy	Their houses made of materials they sourced, such as from the town tip, they have no electricity or water	- Representative of socio-economic status and view within their society → viewed as unworthy - Stark contrast between marginalisation and wealth - Symbolises hardships and resilience even in the face of nature - Connection to land, they love what they have and refuse to leave it, especially from white help → represents what's left of their independence - Reminder of neglected injustice - Hope for change	"A real home?" – Dolly in response to Errol, page
Banshee/wail	Dolly is heard wailing like a banshee after she gets raped and is returning home	- Banshees are believed to foretell the death of a family member - Symbolic death of Dolly after being raped, almost disconnected from home by Errol, humiliated, excluded	"It's a banshee wailing." – Gladys, page 174

		- Her wails foretell the death of her old self as she has now become a “woman” - Harrison alludes to animalistic comparison of Dolly’s situation to attack white society’s actions, it’s the barbarism of what they did to her.	
Title: Rainbows End	The title is Rainbows end which is the meaning of the housing they get transferred to, Rumbalara	- Rainbows represent hope, renewal, better future. Can symbolise possibility of a brighter future for Indigenous Australians and hope for social progress and recognition. - Naming the new housing ‘Rumbalara’ can symbolise the end of Indigenous freedom, as it means ‘rainbows end’ → the end of the rainbow (happiness), they’re going to be controlled again and will lose their freedom. Nan “knowing what it means” shows she understands what will happen again, being at “the mercy of the manager”. - The rainbow’s end is a mythical destination that can never truly be reached, the characters dreams often feel distant and elusive. Characters dream of a better future, but practical obstacles and social barriers make these dreams seem unattainable	“they called it rumbalara” “I know what it means”
Radio	The radio is overheard advertising products and broadcasting the Bob Dyer show throughout the book	- Represents the way external influences and media can affect interpersonal dynamics → different reactions to what's heard on radio can reflect varying perspectives/values. Acts as a catalyst for conversations and conflicts, revealing impact of outside information on family cohesion and individual relationships. - Broadcasts serve as reminder of dominant culture's values, can clash with/overshadow Indigenous	“Ajax bleach is a miracle foaming cleaner yak yak yak” “the queen coming to aussie soil YAK”

		sense of identity and connection to land. - Symbolises tension between dreams and reality by broadcasting content that reflects broader societal ideals which are out of reach.	
Bleach	Ajax Bleach is advertised on the radio twice for its ability to whiten things	- White people advertising the bleach → bleach gets rid of things, erases them/colour = white people advertising the erasure of Aboriginal culture, subtly advocating for assimilation/abolishment through the radio, publicly. - Bleach cleans, implying Aboriginal people are dirty, to be clean like white people	“Honestly, they’re mad about whiteness.” – Nan, page
Songs	Songs repetitively appear during dream sequences and throughout the book	- Catch a falling star: dreams, never stop chasing them, always have hope with you. - Que sera sera: continue living, things will pass. - A girl like you: resilience of love no matter social barriers. - I’ll be home: grateful for home no matter the issues or hardships. - Somewhere over the rainbow: there are better times to come, dreams may be out of reach, but hold hope. - The old rugged cross: the cross as a symbol of strength during Nan’s health scare	“the assembly singing The old rugged cross very faintly” page 194
The colour white	White is mentioned multiple times, such as the inspector talking about how white the clothes were, the characters talking about their white clothing, and Nan reading about skin bleaching products	- Infatuation with white can symbolise overbearing white culture, ingrained into everything: bleach advertised by the Dyer’s, Gladys looking for her white gloves, Dolly looking for her white shoes. Subtly reminder of who is dominant in their society.	“Where are my white gloves?” “Honestly, they’re mad about whiteness.”
Floods	Their humpy is flooded at the beginning of the play, and they get flooded again in the middle of the play, causing them to move to Rumbalara housing.	- Symbolise how nature is against them → their land that they owned is now against them, its whitewashed and further shows	Dolly “its like we’re fighting against nature”

		- white dominance over everything that's theirs Floods wash everything away and can represent white society slowly erasing/diluting everything Indigenous.	
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LITERARY DEVICES	CONTEXT	QUOTE
Simile	In response to being covered up hessian by the government. Describing Dolly.	"Like a Band-Aid over a sore." "She's sharp as a tack."
Metaphor	When worrying about Dolly while she is at the ball.	"As right as rain"
Foreshadowing	Foreshadows total dominance over Indigenous culture even through radio.	"Ajax bleach, miracle foaming action."
Imagery	After Dolly was humiliated publicly at the ball.	"The band sounds die away, and night sounds take over. It is dark and a weak light shines on her from the hall. Her chest is heaving as she tries to hold in the tears."
Juxtaposition	Dolly's refusal to be like white people is juxtaposed by her insistence to participate in white conventions, inadvertently becoming like them, as she's interested in the same things, and will wear the same things they do, such as the 'peplums' she wants.	"What do you want from me Mum? Do you want me to walk like them, talk like them, wear a twin-set like them? Pretend to be one of them?" "I can? To the ball? Yippee!"
Anaphora	Inspector when talking about housing situations	"Things will change...things must change."
Pun	Saying Dolly will be as right as rain after they're trying to save themselves from the flood.	"As right as rain."
Irony	Scene 10 title, poverty vs wealth. The inspector telling them to be knowledgeable when they're the ones that take knowledge away from them and about their culture. Contrast between Errol's supposed privilege having access to education, but not knowing everything. Stating that the queen's on the birthplace of the nation, completely disregarding the fact Indigenous Australians were there tens of thousands of years before them.	"The bank vs Mrs. Banks." "Knowledge is power ladies." "Encyclops boy and he knows nothing!" "...standing at last on Australian soil, on this spot, which is the birthplace of the nation..."
Motif	Infatuation with white, can be linked to desire to be apart of their society. Or can represent the slow bleed of white	"Where are my white gloves?" "Have you seen those white shoes?" "Your whites are so white!"

	culture into supposedly protected Indigenous culture which they intend to dominate.	“Honestly, they’re mad about whiteness.”
Characterisation	Characterises Nan as viewing things rationally, for the purpose of utility and survival. Characterises Dolly as intent on blending into white society despite Indigenous heritage and reveals infatuation with white conventions. She desires to live a life bigger and better than her current one. Characterises Gladys as a dreamer, who wants more for her daughter and wants her to dream, because dreaming will lead to achievement of crazy goals. Characterises Errol as a rare non-discriminatory white male, who is oblivious to the discrimination and erasure towards Indigenous Australians. Wants to learn about their culture, can symbolise reconciliation. Characterises Papa Dear as a powerful inspiration and influence to his family, despite his brief/rare appearances, and as a glorified role model in the Indigenous community for fighting for their rights constantly.	“Saved our skins many a time.” “Everyone’s going to be there.” “A peplum.” “Gawd daught, where do you get these highfalutin ideas from?” “She needs to know the world is bigger than just this.” “Er...um...it says that...Well, I’m quite sure there’s a full and very enlightening entry in the complete set.” “Getting a meeting with the busiest Aboriginal around!”
Analogy		

Minor characters

The Bank Manager

Role of the Bank Manager

The bank manager in *Rainbow's End* represents **institutional authority** and the barriers faced by Indigenous Australians in their pursuit of progress and equality. His character primarily appears as **a symbol of the systemic challenges that the Aboriginal community faces** when trying to improve their socio-economic status.

Connection to themes

- **Realization of Dreams:** The bank manager's interactions with Gladys highlight the gap between character's dreams and the harsh realities they face.
- **Education and Access to Opportunities:** While the bank manager himself is not directly involved in education; his role affects educational opportunities. The systemic biases and inequalities represented by his character impact the ability of the Aboriginal characters to access resources and opportunities that could enhance their educational and professional prospects.

Key Quotes – The Bank Manager

BANK MANAGER: Mrs Banks. You're inquiring about a loan, perhaps?

p. 163

She triumphantly produces a photo of DOLLY. The BANK MANAGER puts on his glasses and studies the photo.

BANK MANAGER: Yes. Very pretty face. [Beat.] But I'm still not sure why you're here...

GLADYS: The teller's position, of course. BANK MANAGER: I don't think so...

GLADYS: But she's just completed her Leaving Certificate—the first in the family—with real good grades... 'N' top of her class in algebra...

p. 163

On the BANK MANAGER's desk is a tray with two china cups of tea, milk jug and sugar bowl. he pours a cup for himself, but doesn't offer one to GLADYS

p. 163

BANK MANAGER: Well, it's all very impressive... What I'm wondering is how she'd fit in.

GLADYS: [steely] She'd fit in fine.

BANK MANAGER: In a job such as this, reliability is important... I wonder how would she get into town each day.

p. 163-164

Well, if that's all... *He stands up, as if their business has concluded.*
DOLLY: [voice-over echo] Have you learnt not to be shamed by them? Eh?

GLADYS: No. The trainee position. For my Dolly.

BANK MANAGER: To be honest, Mrs Banks—

p. 164

The Inspector

Role of the Inspector

The inspector is a government official who visits the Aboriginal community to enforce regulations and policies. His role is emblematic of the **authority and bureaucracy that impacts the lives of the characters**, particularly in relation to housing and land. He is a representative of the **institutional power** that can either facilitate or hinder the community's progress.

Connection to themes

- **Country & Enforcement of Policies:** The inspector's role underscores the theme of country by representing the external control and regulation over the land and housing that affect the Aboriginal community. His presence and the enforcement of regulations reflect the broader theme of how governmental and institutional policies can impact Indigenous people's connection to their land and living conditions.
- **Authority and Impact on Relationships:** The inspector's interactions with the family illustrate the dynamics of power and authority in relationships, particularly the relationship between Indigenous and Non-indigenous people. Even though he is mostly pleasant, the way he enforces policies affects the community's ability to build and maintain relationships based on trust and mutual respect.

Key quotes – The Inspector

INSPECTOR: I say, crocheted pillow shams. Such beautiful work!

GLADYS: That would be my mother's handiwork.

INSPECTOR: It must be quite unpleasant here in summer?

GLADYS: Excuse me?

INSPECTOR: The heat.

GLADYS: It's bearable. Better than winter.

INSPECTOR: Linoleum?

NAN DEAR: Yes.

GLADYS: From Daish's.

INSPECTOR: I'm not familiar with the department stores around these parts.

INSPECTOR: Well! I don't know how you do it. Your whites are so white! With river water, no less!

INSPECTOR: Yes... As a result of my report, things will change, Mrs Banks. Things must change. The sanitation arrangements for one.

GLADYS and NAN exchange worried looks.

And you need interim housing to ease you into the townships. Are you aware of the concept of assimilation, Mrs Banks?

GLADYS isn't sure how to respond, or even if a response is required.

GLADYS: Yes, but we— But

NAN elbows her.

INSPECTOR: The Aborigine needs to be absorbed into the community. But how can he be absorbed until he learns to live like us? I will recommend assimilation, in my report. It is a vexed issue, to be sure, but someone must take leadership. First, the housing problem must be fixed... After all, how can the children study in the evenings if there is no electric light?

The Jungi

Role of the Jungi

The Jungi (policeman) in *Rainbow's End* represents an external authority figure whose misunderstanding of Aboriginal culture and heritage is a crucial element in the play, especially when he tries to evacuate the family due to the flood.

Connection to themes

- **Country:** The Jungi's approach to the evacuation is based on a Eurocentric perspective, which fails to appreciate the cultural context of the Aboriginal community. He does not recognize the cultural significance of the home and certain home items. His inability to grasp their importance highlights a lack of sensitivity and respect for the community.
- **Dreams vs. Reality:** The Jungi's misunderstanding (particularly about the importance of the encyclopedias) adds another layer of difficulty for the characters, who are already grappling with the challenges of achieving their dreams.

Key Quotes – The Jungi

NAN struggles to lift her singer sewing machine.

JUNGI: Ma'am? Is this essential?

NAN DEAR: It's a Singer!

p. 174

The JUNGI shrugs and starts to move off. NAN follows GLADYS back into the humpy. The JUNGI, looking around for somewhere to put the crate containing the encyclopedias, places them on the ground. he vanishes into the dark.

p. 174-175

JUNGI: My orders are to move all people first, before we move property. Property can be replaced, after all.

GLADYS: Not this, it can't. [To herself] Not on a picker's wage. Gawd, we'd be living on Johnny cakes. [Pleading] Look, it's real important. For my daughter, see. Not for me, but for my daughter. Please.

p.174